

Echoes of Kuala Lumpur: When Indian hockey ruled the world

India's **1975 Hockey World Cup** triumph in Kuala Lumpur was a historic victory, marked by resilience, key performances, and a dramatic semifinal. It was India's last major title on natural grass.

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For my generation, cricket was an addiction, but hockey was an emotion. I never played hockey, but I never missed an opportunity to watch.

Cricketers were stars, and so were hockey players. Sports magazines featured hockey players on their covers, and fans collected their posters.

A generation of sports scribes who passed down stories of the national hockey team's feats — seven Olympic gold medals, six of them in succession — connected us with some of the greatest names in Indian sport.

The 1972 Olympics in Munich was a disappointment. A bronze medal did not truly reflect the team's strength. When the 1975 World Cup was announced, with Kuala Lumpur as the venue, one could only hope.

The team trained in Chandigarh. "The Punjab Government sponsored the camp," recalled goalkeeper Ashok Diwan. It was a concerted effort by the Punjab government and the Indian Hockey Federation (IHF) to assemble the best squad and win the trophy.

"There was a terrific bond among

the players and support staff. We had (G.S.) Bodhi as the coach and Balbir Singh (Sr) as the manager. They knew the players inside out. They instilled tremendous confidence in us, and we were raring to go to Kuala Lumpur. It was a perfect team," said Diwan.

The then Punjab Chief Minister, Giani Zail Singh, who later became the President of India, took a personal interest in ensuring the team had the best facilities. Ashok Kumar, the star of the final when India beat Pakistan 2-1, remembered, "We were looked after very well."

Malaysia hosted the tournament's third edition after Spain (1971) and the Netherlands (1973). India won bronze in Spain and two years later, silver, losing to the Netherlands on penalty strokes. The assignment in Kuala Lumpur was significant for more than one reason. It was the last major tournament on natural grass as hockey authorities had decided to transition to artificial surfaces from the 1976 Olympics in Montreal.

"When we landed in Malaysia, there was no pressure, and that worked well for us," recalled defender Aslam Sher Khan. He would later play a decisive role in shaping India's fortunes in the final phase of

the World Cup.

India began its campaign with a 2-1 win over England, with V.J. Philips scoring both goals. A 1-1 draw with Australia, with B.P. Govinda as the scorer, kept spirits high. Wins over Ghana (7-0) and West Germany (3-1) were expected, but a 1-2 loss to Argentina was not.

"We were combining well, and there was such optimism in the team ahead of the semifinal," said Ashok. However, the match almost derailed India's progress in the tournament.

According to Diwan, there was not a single voice supporting India. Almost 50,000 spectators cheered for Malaysia. It did not affect the Indian team, but there were some tense moments, with Malaysia playing better than its usual standard.

India led through a Shivaji Pawar goal but soon trailed 1-2. As desperation set in, the team launched a series of blistering attacks, but the equaliser remained elusive. Penalty corners did not help either. The Indian bench looked forlorn. Bodhi and Balbir were lost for words, as Malaysia seemed certain to win the semifinal. Twelve minutes before the final whistle, Balbir turned to Aslam and called him in to replace Michael Kindo.

Kindo was excellent at breaking